a truly enormous multinational company. By 1603, the Dutch had a trading post in Banten, West Java and by 1611 in Jayakarta (later Batavia and now Jakarta). Soon they were challenging the Portuguese along the Indian coast and in Sri Lanka.

The Dutch were not just helped by the efficiencies of private sector enterprise, but also by the better quality of their maps. Thanks to Mercator and Ortilius, they were at the cutting edge of cartography. A map of the Bay of Bengal by Janssan and Hondius printed in the 1630s shows the improvements in the level of knowledge since Waldseemüller a century earlier. The map shows Sri Lanka, the eastern coastline of India, Bengal, the Burmese coast, the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and the northern tip of Sumatra. There is a lot of detail along the coast with both major and minor habitations marked out including *Musalipatam* and *Pallecatta*. The temple-town of Puri in Orissa is marked as *Pagod Jagernaten* after the temple to Lord Jagannath. Since it is a navigation chart, depth measurements are marked out in a number places such as the Gangetic delta. For the first time, we see some detailed knowledge of the interior of the country. For instance, the riverport of Ougely (Hooghly) is clearly marked out on the westernmost channel of the Ganga. Hooghly was then the most important trading centre in eastern India and, despite its subsequent decline, the river channel continues to bear the name of the old port even today.

Meanwhile, the English had also formed their own East India Company. By 1612, they had set up their first factory at Surat, Gujarat. Its position was strengthened a few years later by the embassy of Sir Thomas Roe to the court of Emperor Jehangir. Interestingly, Roe presented an atlas of the latest European maps to the Mughal court but it was politely returned after four days.[15] It is possible that the courtiers were unused to cartographic representations and could not understand the atlas. However, in my view, it may also have been because it showed how small the Mughal Empire was in relation to the world known to the Europeans. Maps have always had a geo-political aspect to them, and the recent friction between India and China about the depiction of Arunachal Pradesh shows that it remains the case to this day.